

St. Peter's Basilica

The most celebrated Roman Catholic place of worship, awe-inspiring in its scale and lavish decoration



S. Europe

St. Peter's Basilica is built over the presumed site of the tomb of the apostle Peter. Located in Vatican City, an independent city-state in Rome ruled by the Pope, it attracts millions of pilgrims and tourists every year. The interior of the building, enriched with marble, gilt, and mosaics, impresses above all with its size: its nave is 610 ft (186 m) long, and its dome rises 446 ft (136 m) above the floor.

Making the second basilica

The first basilica on the site was built in around 330 CE. In 1506, Pope Julius II made the radical decision to replace this decaying edifice with a new structure, albeit one made using stones plundered from ancient Roman ruins. His favorite architect, Donato Bramante (1444–1514), set to work on a church of epic size.

Both Julius II and Bramante were long dead by the time the project was completed. Many famous Renaissance figures worked on St. Peter's, including Michelangelo (1475–1564), who designed the dome. The long nave and the imposing facade, with its array of columns and statues, were completed by 1615. Work continued on the embellishment of the interior under Baroque sculptor and architect Gianlorenzo Bernini (1598–1680), who was responsible for the huge bronze *baldacchino* (canopy) over the tomb of St. Peter.

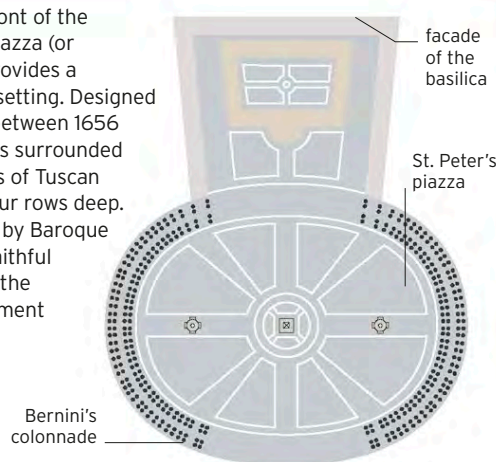


△ WORK OF MANY HANDS

Statues line the facade of St. Peter's with the mighty dome rising behind. Many of Italy's most famous artists worked on the creation of the basilica.

ST. PETER'S PIAZZA

Located directly in front of the basilica, St. Peter's Piazza (or St. Peter's Square) provides a gloriously theatrical setting. Designed by Bernini and built between 1656 and 1667, the piazza is surrounded by two sweeping lines of Tuscan columns, each line four rows deep. The columns, topped by Baroque statues, gather the faithful toward the facade of the basilica. The arrangement allows the maximum number of people to see the Pope speaking from a balcony above the main door.



△ BIRD'S-EYE VIEW

This view shows the splendid setting for the basilica designed by Bernini. The ancient Egyptian obelisk was erected in the center of the piazza in 1586.

